THE EMPLOYEES WHO NEVER LEFT

Salina's journey has taken her from a telephone operator at ITC Maurya as a 19 year old in 1988, to the role of Senior Supervisor today. "The company cares for you, the colleagues are my second family. I can never forget that I received my full salary even during the Covid pandemic," she says. Younger employees share that sentiment. In Kolkata, 31-year-old Priyanka Bhattacharyya, Assistant PR Manager at ITC Royal Bengal and ITC Sonar, returned to the company after briefly working elsewhere. "The difference is how the organisation makes you feel, be heard and be seen. So I chose to come back, and since then there is no looking back."

At a time when switching jobs is the new mantra, what makes both young and old stick? "It floated from the ITC DNA, which is about taking care of your people, being married to ITC, being inclusive, being competitive in what you do compared to market," says Sanjay Bose, Executive Vice President, Human Resources. In fact ITC Hotels has one of the lowest attrition rates in the industry. "In the past 3-4 years it hovers between 38 to 42% for the hospitality industry but at ITC it is below 10%," he adds.

HOSTING WORLD LEADERS

International recognition for the hotel group came not through a global award, but when American presidents chose to stay in the opulent presidential suite at ITC Maurya, New Delhi. Bill Clinton arrived in 2000. The list of global dignitaries and celebrities who have been hosted in the sprawling 4,700 square foot "Chanakya" suite that comes with silk-panelled walls, artworks that could be housed in museums, and a mini spa, is long. U.S. President, Joe Biden was the latest American president to stay here during the Group of 20 summit New Delhi hosted in 2023.



"As an old timer, I'll still say, it's like my home."

AJAY CHOPRA

What led an ITC hotel to become the home of visiting dignitaries? "Confidence of that nature is not built through a single gesture or a grand lobby. It is built over years, through thousands of small details being right—consistently, discreetly and without fuss," pointed out Chadha. The dignitaries, he says, need to know that expectations will be understood before they are articulated, privacy will be respected and a complex occasion handled seamlessly.

However the company did not confine itself to the top tier of travellers and instead built seven categories for other segments. For example, ITC Hotels and Mementos attract high end luxury visitors in the metros and resort locations, Welcomhotel caters to the upper upscale to upscale category while the intimate Storii hotels speak to those who prefer the quiet charm of a boutique stay. Fortune Hotels and WelcomHeritage are the perfect choice for those looking for midscale options, and heritage hotels. The newest addition to the portfolio is the Epiq Collection, an upper to upscale brand catering to larger hotels with enhanced services and contemporary cuisine options.

MEMORABLE GUEST EXPERIENCES AT ITC HOTELS

WHEN ITC HOTELS WENT OUT OF THEIR WAY TO HELP GUESTS

A SUNGLASS SHOP APPEARS OVERNIGHT:
On a foggy winter night in New Delhi, the butler of a prominent lady guest at ITC Maurya received a call an hour before midnight. She had planned to set out for a full day of sightseeing the next morning but left her sunglasses behind. Could the hotel assist? Reaching out to every contact, the team connected with accessory stores and virtually put together a sunglass shop in a corner of the lobby by the time she walked in there the next morning with her entourage. The VIP guest praised the team's warmth and their willingness to go the extra mile.

AN 80-YEAR-OLD RELIVES HER CHILDHOOD ON HER BIRTHDAY
A guest wanted his mother to experience her childhood on her 80th birthday and re-live the memories of the home where she grew up. The ITC team at Rajputana, Jaipur, spent the day gathering family photographs, understanding the recipes of her favourite childhood dishes and creating a playlist of songs she loved. What followed was not just a birthday dinner. It was a dream sequence of her life in flashback and an evening of stories, laughter and happy tears.

A FORGOTTEN WEDDING ANNIVERSARY
A guest at ITC Grand Central, Mumbai confessed that he had forgotten his wedding anniversary and his spouse was staying at another ITC property in Bengaluru. The ITC Windsor quickly arranged flowers, a cake, chocolates, and a very romantic dinner for both in their respective cities, connecting them virtually. By the end of the evening the disaster had turned into a wonderful evening.

A RARE MOMENT
Checking into ITC Maratha in Mumbai, an anxious guest realised he had left his iPad in the seat pocket of his flight and had just a few hours to log in for a crucial presentation. He was offered the business centre to redo the presentation if he needed. At the same time, the hotel's airport team immediately got into action. Connecting the dots, they worked with the airline and airport authorities to track down the device. It was back with the guest that same night. He called it 'rare'.